

EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources

Volume 19: Jewish Mobilities Reconsidered

August, 15-16, 2022

Online on Zoom

Peregrinos de la Occidental Yndia: Material Texts, Mobility, and the Re-Enactment of Jewish Community in Colonial Mexico

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José Lumbroso (Luis de Carvajal, the Younger, by his Christian name), who died at the stake in December 1596 in Mexico City, is perhaps the most important thinker and preacher of clandestine or crypto-Judaism in colonial Latin America. Several manuscripts in his hand resurfaced in the fall of 2016 after being missing for almost eighty years. The three co-authors of this paper joint forces in 2019 to produce a critical edition of those manuscripts with a historical introduction and English translation of the texts. This paper is presented in the frame of that shared project. We aim at interrogating our sources through the lens of mobility, a category that has proved to be rather useful for our research. It brings together the experiences of empire, exile and diaspora, and a shifting personal identity, that shaped José’s life and the account of it that he endeavoured to pass over. As Ruderman (2010) has noted, early modern Jewry and Judaism was marked by

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mobility and uprooting. This was the case with colonial Latin American clandestine Jews, including Lumbroso/Carvajal. In contrast to individuals and families Kaplan (1994) defined as “new Jews”, who found a new settlement in lands outside the Spanish realms, these “pilgrims of the Western Indies”, in Lumbroso’s words, settled down in America as part of the imperial experiment. Lumbroso kept dreaming of Italy, where part of his family is meant to have settled, but still lived and thrived in colonial society, somewhat paradoxically within the reach of the Spanish Inquisition. This experience seems to find a suitable explanation following Robert Chazan’s recent (2019) framing of Jewish mobility as more often voluntary than forced. It also echoes similar experiences with Iberian subjects of formerly Muslim genealogies (Cook, 2016) in the same colonial American imperial space. Our assumption is that Lumbroso’s told experience becomes richer and more nuanced by interrogating it in this light. Besides, Lumbroso’s manuscripts are extraordinary products of sophisticated scribal and literary culture. They are tiny books written with an expert hand, its materiality is challenging. Its circulation helped create collective bonds. However, when the Inquisition finally discovered them, it sealed Lumbroso’s and his family’s tragic fate. Finally, we would like to broaden our investigation of these sources through thinking them as by-products of a politics of nostalgia. We would like to interrogate these manuscripts as foundational milestone of a failed project to re-enact, rather than simply to build, a dreamed medieval Jewish community through a fundamentally textual project (Chuecas, 2021).

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“The Italian Siddur” an excerpt from Lumbroso’s *Vida*, based on the transcription by Ignacio Chuecas Saldía; translation by Ronnie Perelis

This short passage comes from Lumbroso’s autobiography and sheds light on the varied ways ideas and texts travelled throughout the Atlantic world. This is just one example of the connections and interactions between individuals from normative Jewish communities in places such as Italy and the “lands of captivity”, Iberian territories where the Inquisition kept a careful eye out for judaizers.

After having taken them out of the mosquito-infested desolation of Pánuco the Lord again performed acts of mercy for them by providing, through the agency of one of His servants, many of the holy and devout prayers through which the Lord is invoked and praised in the Israelite synagogues by the wise and chosen people of the holy congregation (yglesia) of the Lord.

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The means through which His Holiness provided and brought to these lands of his captivity this gift from where our brothers live free and are able to keep all aspects of the law of the most high God without any restrictions was through one of his servants who lived in the diaspora of Italy. He was so poor that he did not have a way to support his household and children and so he prepared these “rations for the soul”, transcribing these holy prayers, rendered into Portuguese and Castilian, and he came alone to wander (peregrinar) through this New World

And one of our Israelite brothers, who at the time was a resident and merchant in Mexico [City] , told me that this pilgrim feared the Lord so much and hated idolatry in such a way that many times he would come rushing into his store in such a hurry that he thought some terrible misfortune had befallen him or that he was running away from the law because he would rush in and find a hiding place. Actually he was running away because he heard the sound coming from the street of the most nefarious idolatry that the whole world has ever heard of or conceived of and so as not to bow down before it, once he heard the bell that they ring before the “hanged one “ [el ahrcado] as they parade him through the streets he would run for refuge in this way. And so when this good gentleman (varon) returned from this land to Italy he left behind this treasure of holy prayers.

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“The Italian Siddur” an excerpt from Lumbroso’s Vida, transcription by Ignacio Chuecas Saldía

Tambien les hizo el S.r mr̃d. despues de auerlos sacado del mosquiterio, y soledad de panuco de depararles muchas de las s.tas y deuotifimas or.es con que el S.r es inbocado, y loado en las ysraeliticas sinagogas, por la g.te sabia y escojida de la s.ta yglesia del S.r el medio porq̃ su sanctidad les deparo, y truxo a las tierras de fu captiu.o este bien de las en que nr̃os her.os uiuen libres en lo que toca a guardar la ley del muy alto .D. sin q̃ se les ympida fue hallarfe un syeruo suyo de los que uiuiian en la disperfion de ytaliam tam [sic] pobre q̃ no tenía rem.o p.a sustentarse con fu casa, y hijos, por lo q̃ hecho eft el matalotaje del anima, y tràssumptadas estas s.tas or.es que digo en lenguaje portugueß y castellano se uino a peregrinar en este nuevo mundo el

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solo, y contome a mi un hermano nr̃o. ysraelita q̃_era a la sazón vz.o y
mercader en mex.co el peregrino dicho tam[sic] temeroso del S.or y
aborrezedor de la ydolatria por que le auia succedido muchas vezes uerle
venyr huyendo hasta su tienda, y casa tam [sic] de priesa [sic], que pensaba
auerle succedido alg.a desgr̃a. y que uenia huyendo de la justi.a porque se
yba a esconder a los rincones, y era la causa desta huyda el oyr venir por la
calle aquesta mas nefanda ydolatria de quantas en el mundo se an oydo ny
inuentado, y por no arodillarse a ella vi en oyendo la campanilla, que sacan 19
delante del ahorcado,
en oyendo la campanilla, que sacan 19 delante del ahorcado,

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A Hispanized Hebrew Calendar from Colonial Mexico by Luis de Carvajal, el mozo aka Joseph Lumbroso

Esther	Wednesday. 22 February
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Passover	Saturday. 25. March
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Shavuot	Sunday. 14. May
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[Fast of] Tamuz	Sunday . 5. June
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[Fast of] Ninth of Av	Sunday .16 July
Rosh Hashana	Monday. 4- September
[Fast of] Gedaliah	Wednesday. 6. September
Yom Kippur	Wednesday. 14. September
Sukkot	Monday. 18. September
Hanukkah	Tuesday. 12. December
Esther	Wednesday. 14. March
Passover	Saturday. 13. April
Shavuot	Sunday. 2- May
Fast of Tamuz	Sunday. 24 July
Fast of 9th of Av	Sunday. 4. August
Rosh Hashana --	Monday.23. September
Fast of Gedaliah- --	Wednesday. 25. September
Yom Kippur	Wednesday. 2. October
Hanukkah-	Tuesday- 31- December

Second column:

Tysri. September

Hesban	October
Quislev	November
Tebeth	December
Sebath	January
Adar	February
Baadar	Only in a leap year
Nisan	March
Yar	April
Siban	May
Tamuz	June
Ab	July
Elul	August

Numbers- one- 10

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Transcription from the original manuscript by Ignacio Chuecas Saldía

~+.a	lehanuca	.5.	22. d.	Tysri.	s.e
+.a	le. Æ.	.4.	22. Eb.	Hesban.	oc.
.8.	pesah.	.7.	25. m.ço	quisleu.	n.e
.2.	sebuchod.	.1.	14. ma.	Tebeth.	D.e
+.a	tamuz.	.1.	25. juz	Sebath.	Eb.
+.a	tisnabeab.	.1.	16. Jll.	Adar.	fe.
.2.	.p. pr.o	.2.	4. S.	Baadar	fi__ẽ
	rofa_fa_n_				_s_o_
	a__				_a_.o_
					_b_i_fi_e_
					ß[to]
+.a	gedaliah.	4.	6. S.	Nifa_n_. _	Mr. ço
+.a	quipur.	4.	14. S.	— yar.	Abril
.9.	Succhoth.	.2.	18. S.	Siban.	My.o
+.a	Le	3.	12. d.e	Tamuz.	Jn.o
	hanuca.				
+.a	le. Æ.	4.	14. m.co	Ab.	Jlio.
8	pefa_h_	7.	13. ab.	Elul.	ag.o
	~_~_~_				
	~_~_~_				
.2.	Sebuchod ~ ~	.1.	2. Jn.	Ehad	
+.a	tamuz ~	.1.	24. Jl.	senahim	
+.a	Tisnabeab ~	.1.	4. Ag.	Selofa__	
2.	p. pi.o	.2.	23. Se.	Arbaha	
	rofa_fa_n_a_				
	~_~_~_				
+.a	gedaliah ~ ~	.4.	25. Se	Hamifa__	
+.a	le quipur.	.4.	2. Oc.	Sifa__	
+.a	le hanuca ~	3.	31. di.	Sibba.	
					Semona.

tisha.
Hasara

Image of the calendar from the digitized manuscript

Link to Digitized Manuscript:

<https://catalog.princeton.edu/catalog/10013425>

+ ^a leharuca . 5 . 22 . 8 .	Tysi . S .
+ ^a lete . 4 . 22 . 26 .	Heban . oc .
3 . perah . 7 . 25 . m .	quislau . n .
2 . sebuho . 1 . 14 . ma .	tebeth . d .
+ ^a tamuz . 1 . 25 . ju .	sebeth . d .
+ ^a tisnab . 1 . 16 . ju .	adar . se .
2 . p . p . r . r . s . f . a . n . a . 2 . 4 . s .	adar . f . i . e . d . a . b . i . f . e .
+ ^a gedaliah . 4 . 6 . s .	xison . m .
+ ^a quipuz . 4 . 14 . s .	yar . ahil
9 . suchoth . 2 . 18 . s .	sitar . m .
+ ^a leharuca . 3 . 12 . s .	tamuz . s .
+ ^a lete . 4 . 14 . m .	ab . s .
2 . perah . 7 . 13 . ab .	elul . ag .
2 . sebuho . 1 . 2 . m .	choz
+ ^a tamuz . 1 . 24 . s .	senahim
+ ^a tisnab . 1 . 4 . s .	selefa
2 . p . p . r . r . s . f . a . n . a . 2 . 23 . s .	araha
+ ^a gedaliah . 4 . 25 . s .	hamifa
+ ^a le quipuz . 4 . 2 . oc .	sifa
+ ^a leharuca . 3 . 31 . di .	sibba
	amona .
	kisha .
	hafara .

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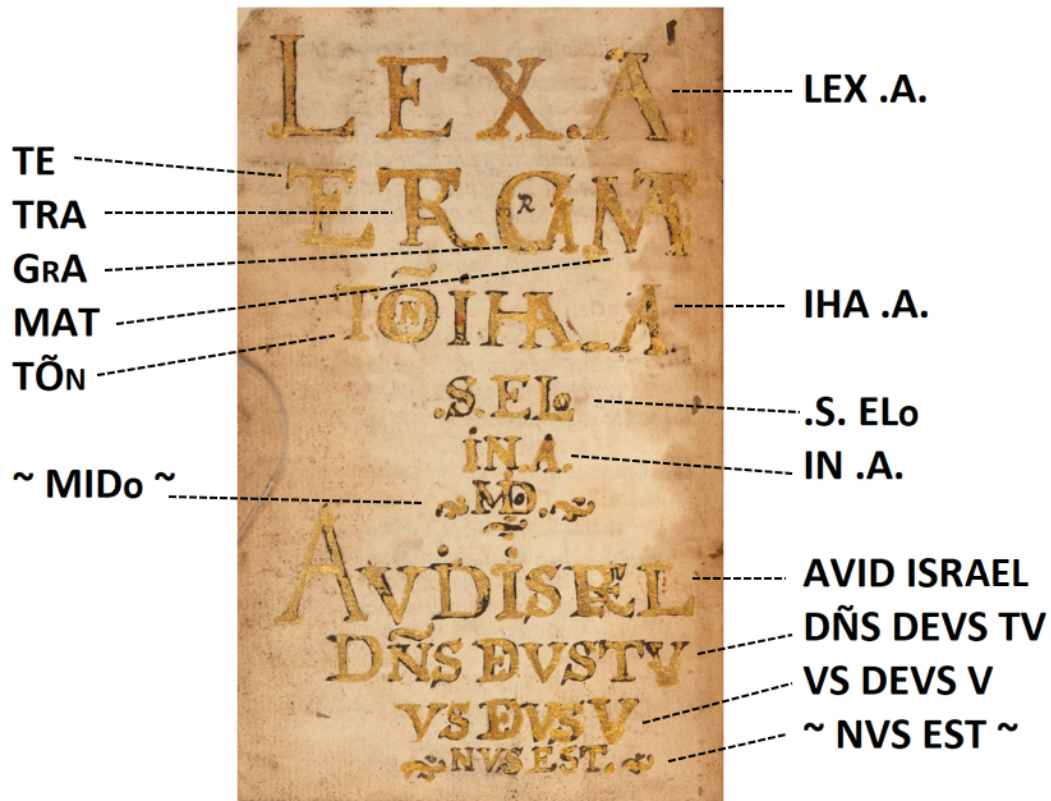
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LAW OF .A.[DONAY]
 TE-TRA-GRA-MAT-
 TÕN IHA. .A.[DONAY]
 .S. [LORD] Elo[him]
 IN .A.[DONAY]
 ~ OhMyGod ~
 HEAR ISRAEL
 THE LORD IS YOUR GOD
 GOD IS
 ~ ONE. ~



I. ADONAI.
 I AM THE LORD
 thy God, who brought thee out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of the
 servants.
 .2°.
 THERE WERE NOT
 for you other gods before me. Thou shalt not make to thyself a graven thing
 and the likeness of any thing, that is in heaven upwards, and in the earth

beneath, and in the water under ea (*sic*) earth. Thou shalt not bow (?) to them, and thou shalt not serve them, since I am The Lord thy God, a jealous God that visits the iniquity of the fathers upon the sons up to the third ones of them, and upon the fourth ones abhorring me.

And shewing mercy
unto thousands who are diligent with me and keep my precepts.

.3°.

THOU SHALT NOT TAKE

the name of thy God in vain, since God shall not
judge innocent whoever shall take His name in vain. Be ye mindful of the
day of the Shabbat, so thou shall sanctify it.

.4°.

.4°. BE YE MINDFUL of the day of the Shabbat, so thou shall sanctify it.
Six days shalt thou labour, and shalt do all your work. And the seventh day
is for the Lord thy God.

Thou shalt do no work on it, nor thy son, nor thy daughter, nor thy
manservant, nor thy maidservant, nor thy animal, nor thy foreigner, who is
within thy gates. Since in six days the Lord made the heave, the earth and
the sea, and all things that are in them, and rested on the seventh day. There
fore the Lord blessed the day of the Shabbat, and sanctified it.

.5°.

.5°. HONOUR THY

father and thy mother, so that thy days will be prolonged upon the earth the
Lord God gives you.

.6°.

.6°. THOU SHALT NOT KILL.

~ .7°.

.7°. THOU SHALT NOT COMMIT
fornication.

.8°. ~

8°. THOU SHALT NOT THI
eve.

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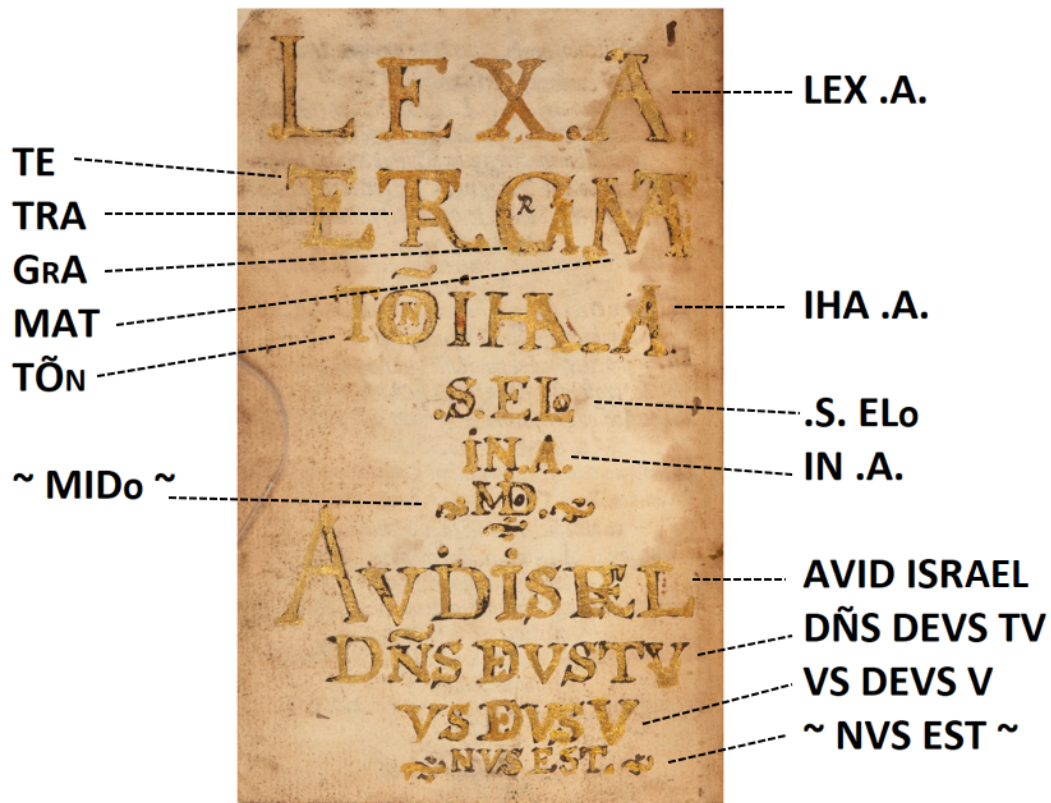
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LEX .A.
 TE-TRA-GRA-MAT-
 TÕN IHA. .A.
 .S. ELo
 IN .A.
 ~ MIDo ~
 AVID ISRAEL
 DÑS DEVS TV
 US DEVS V
 ~ NUS EST. ~



I. ADONAI.
 EGO DÑS
 Deus tuus, qui eduxi te è terra Aegypti è domo
 seruorum.
 .2º.
 NON ERÛT
 tibi dij alij coram me. Non facies tibi scuptile,
 et omnem similitudinem, quæ est in cœlo sur

sū, et quæ in terra de orsū, et quæ in aquis sub
ter terram. Non incuruabis te eis, et non coles eas,
Quia ego Dñs Deus tuus, Deus zelotes uisitans ini
quitatem patrū super filios super tertios, et su
per quartos odientibus me. Et faciens miam
in mille diligentibus me, et custodientibus præ
cepta mea.

.3°.

NON ASSVMES

nomen Dei tui in vanū, quia non inocētem
Dñs iudicabit eum qui asumpserit nomen eius in
vanū. Recordate diei sabbati, ut sanctifices illū.

.4°.

.4°. RECORDaTE diei sabbati, ut sãctifics illū.
sex diebus operaberis, et facies omne opus tu
um. Et die septimo sabbatū est Dño Deo tuo.
Non facies omne opus tu, et filius tuus, et filia
tua, et seruus tuus, et ancilla tua, et animal
tuū, et peregrinus tuus, qui est intra portas,
tuas. Quia sex diebus fecit Dñs cœlū, et terrā
et mare, et omnia qæ sunt in eis, et requie
uit die septimo. Id circo benedixit Dñs diei sab
bati, et sanctificauit eū.

.5°.

.5°. HONORA PA

trem tuū, et matrem tuam, ut prolongetur
dies tui super terram quam Dñs Deus dat ti
bi.

.6°.

.6°. NON OCCIDES.

~ .7°.

.7°. NON CÕMITTES

adulterium.

.8°. ~

8°. NON FVRABE

.ris.